What is the Qualitative Pretest Interview (QPI)?

25 October 2021

Herwig Reiter

reiter@dji.de

German Youth Institute (DJI), Department of Social Monitoring and Methodology

Arne Bethmann

Munich Center for the Economics of Aging (MEA), Max Planck Institute for Social Law and Social Policy, Technical University of Munich

Christina Buschle

IU International University of Applied Sciences, Department of Adult Education

© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021

Programme

- Ca. 35 minutes presentation
- Ca. 20 minutes comments, questions & answers

PLEASE USE THE WHOVA Q&A section

- Additional questions and comments by e-mail: reiter@dji.de
- During the presentation:

  Please mute your microphone & switch off the video

© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021

Outline

- Background & purpose
- Methodological programme & definition
- Communication strategies – active listening & active understanding
- Practical aspects
  - Briefing
  - Communication & active understanding
  - Debriefing
- A note on analysis
- Conclusion & what's next

THE PAPER:

Buschle, Christina/Reiter, Herwig/Bethmann, Arne (2021): The qualitative pretest interview for questionnaire development: outline of programme and practice (online first). In: Quality and Quantity.

https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s11135-021-01156-0

© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021

Origins

- Discussion about improving standardized questionnaires through qualitative methods
- Workshop on cognitive pretesting for questionnaire development

Christina Buschle – mixed methods researcher

Professor of Adult Education at the IU International University of Applied Sciences

Arne Bethmann – survey methodologist

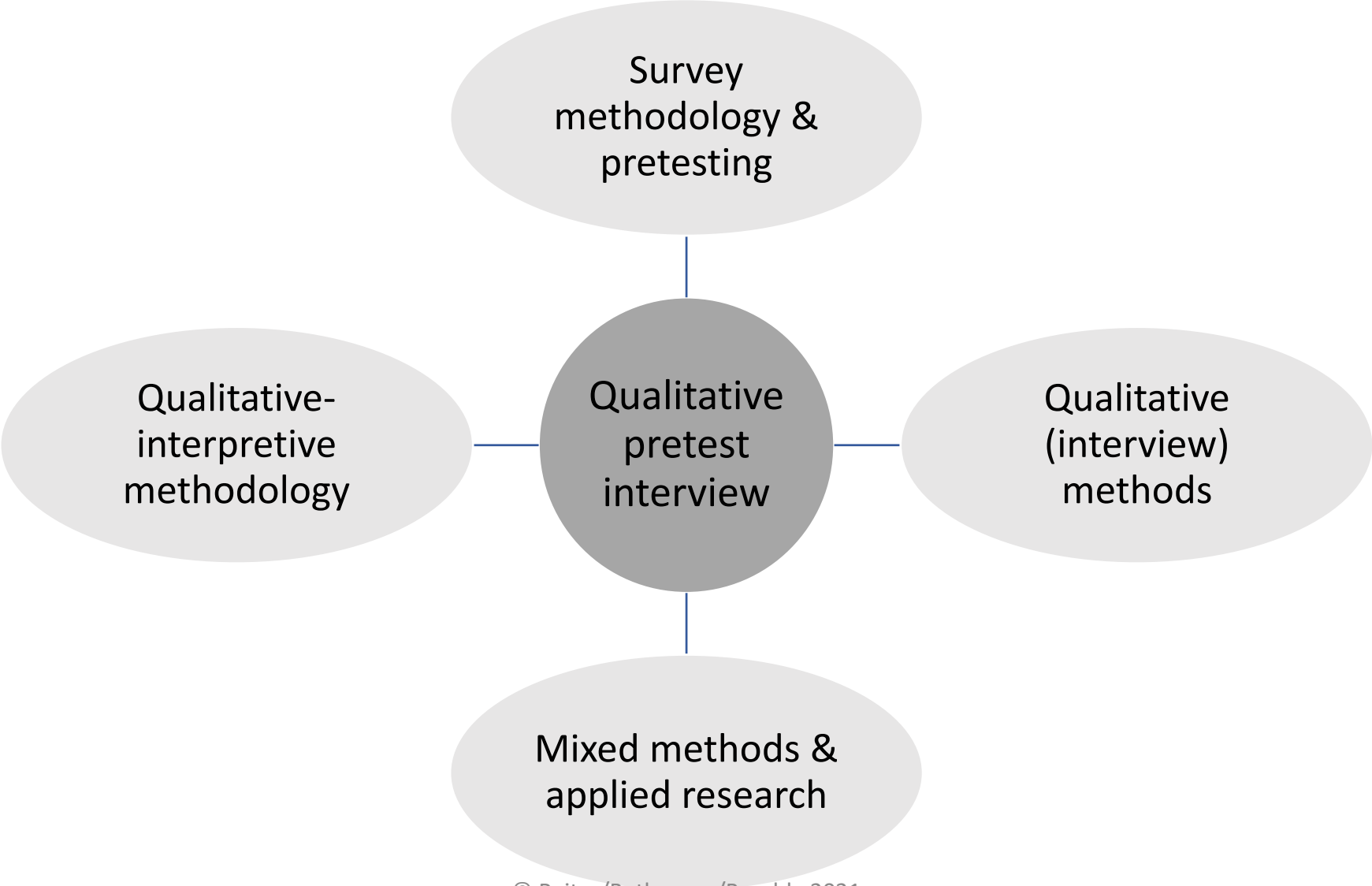
SHARE, the Survey of Health, Aging and Retirement in Europe at the Munich Center for the Economics of Ageing

Herwig Reiter – qualitative methods counsellor & researcher

German Youth Institute, Department of Social Monitoring and Methodology

© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021

Background of the QPI

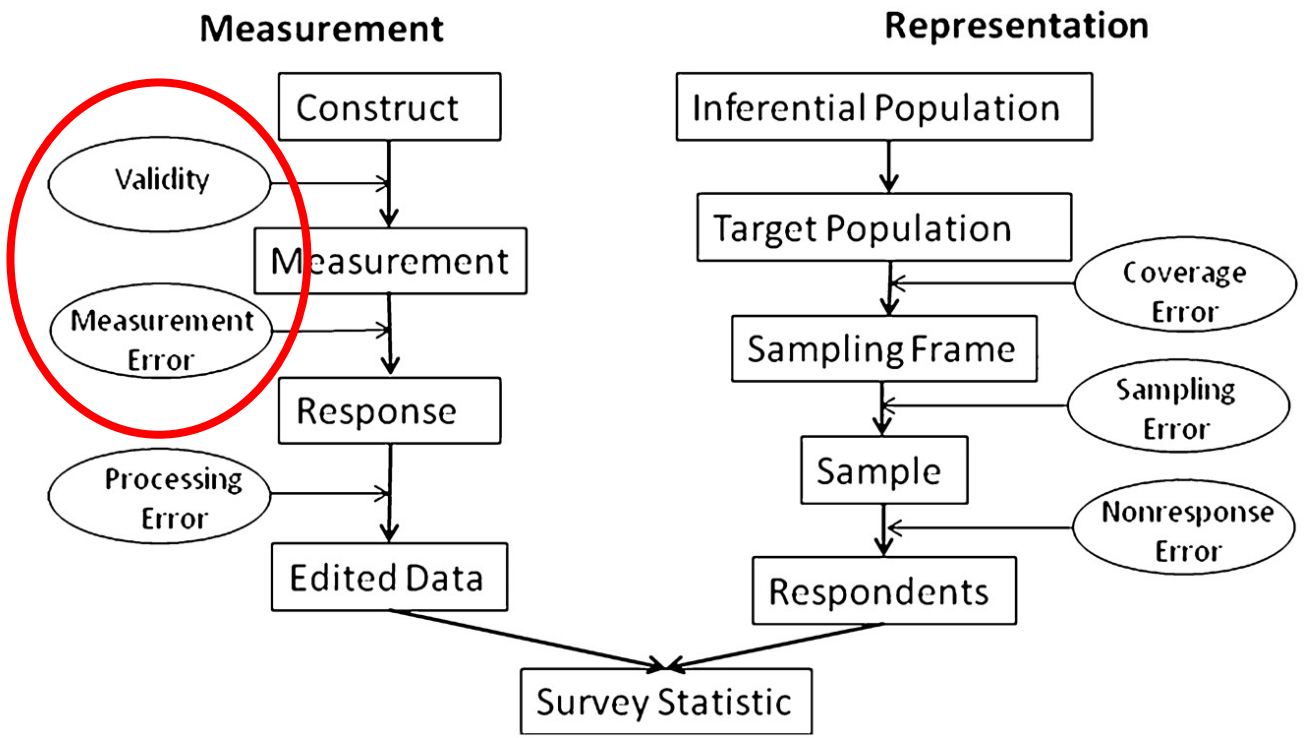


© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021

Guiding question

How can we formulate questions (and other standardised stimuli) in such a way that they are understood adequately and produce answers that we can consider valid?

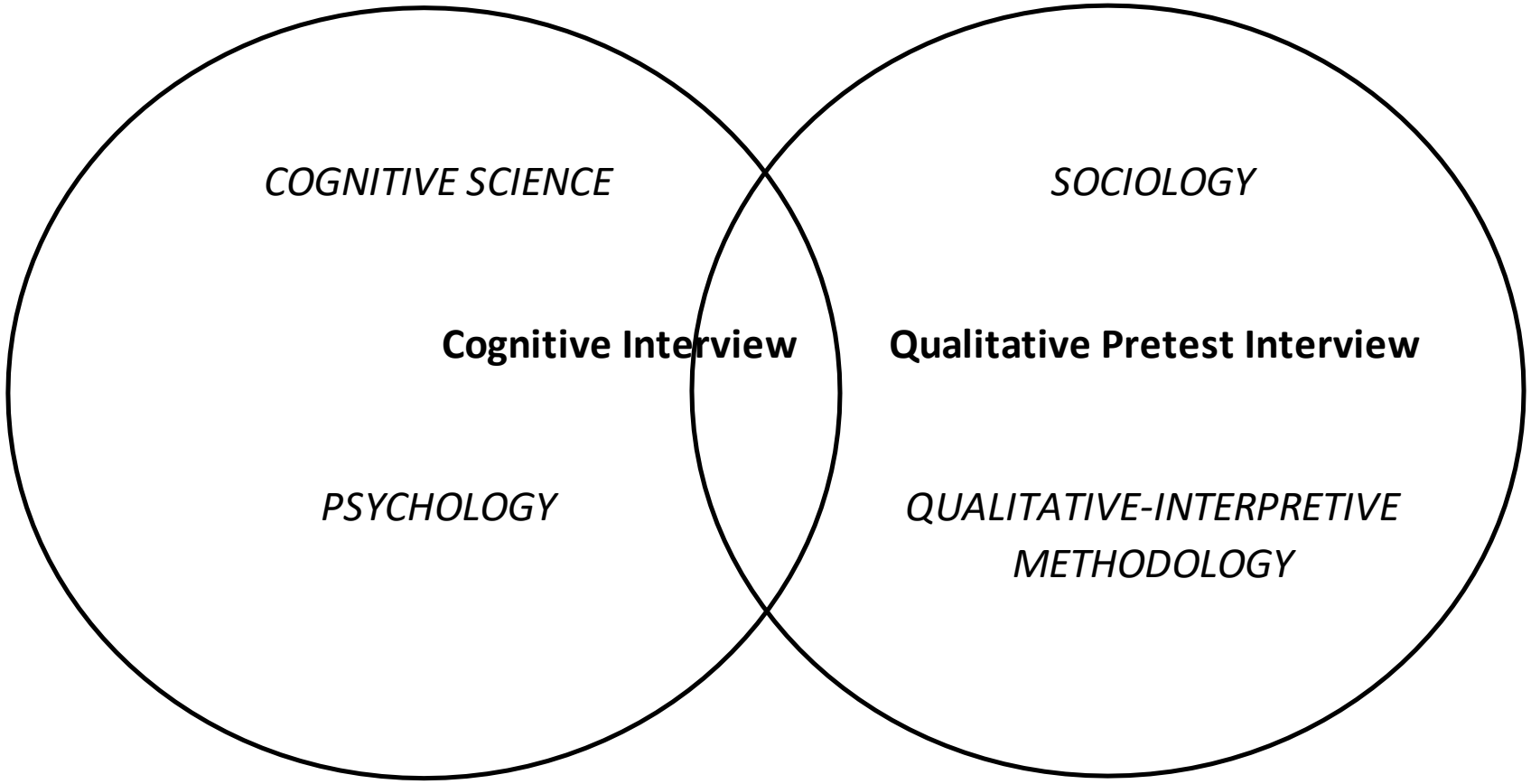
Qualitative pretest interview →



Groves und Lyberg (2010)

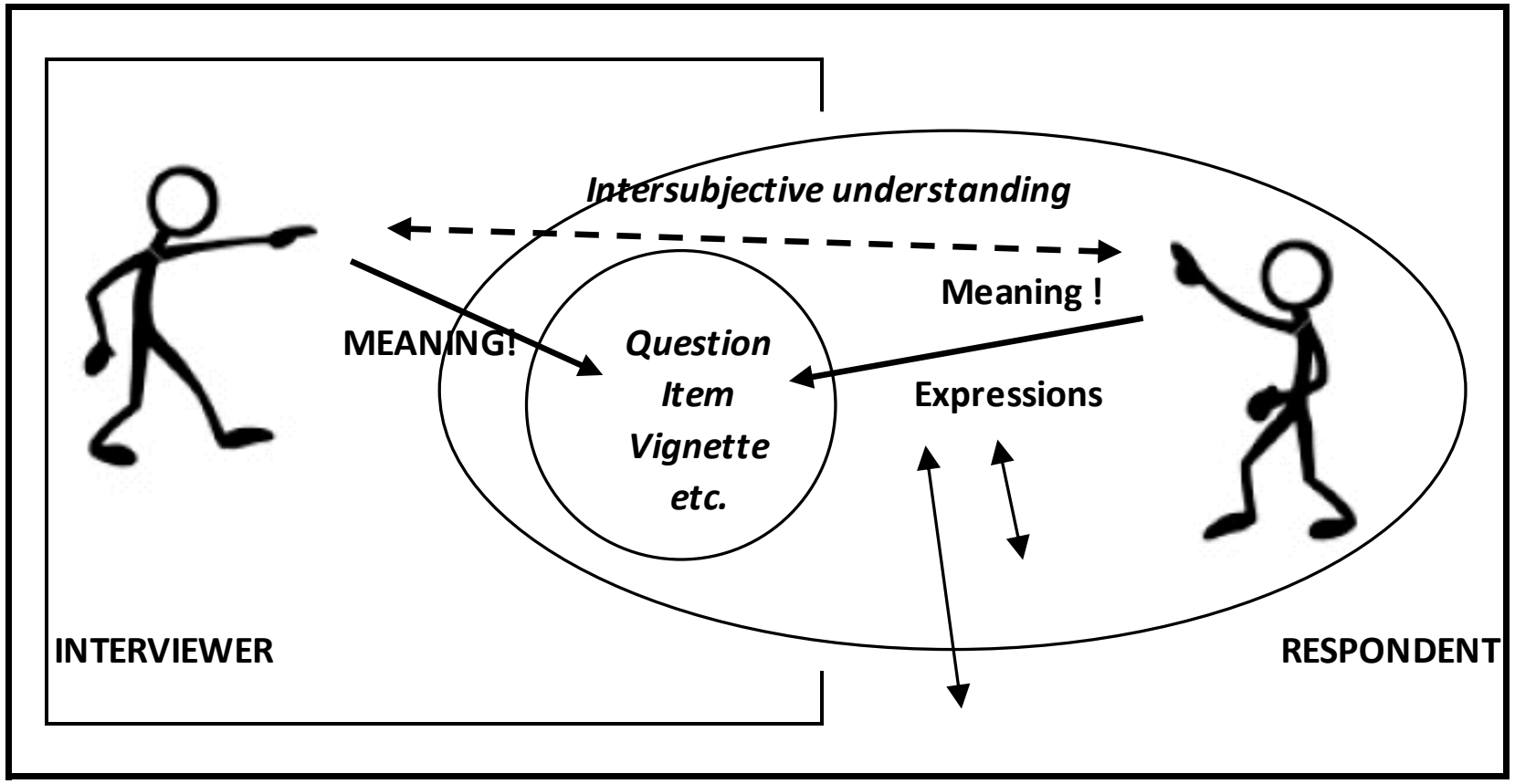
© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021

Cognitive Interview ⇔ Qualitative Pretest Interview



© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021

Intersubjective understanding & indexicality



Indexicality - example

“Too fast!”

Fabricated vs. negotiated understanding

STANDARDISED INTERVIEWING Fabricated understanding	QUALITATIVE INTERVIEWING Negotiated understanding
Predefined expressions (questions, items, vignettes)	Spontaneous expressions
Predefined context (order of questions)	Flexible order of questions
Eradication of ambiguity	Utilisation of indexicality
Decontextualising expressions	Capturing expressions within context
Respondents select/provide answers	Interview partners provide topics, answers, clarification
No dialogue	Joint clarification of meaning
Question => answer	Question <=> answer

© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021

Definition of the QPI

- The Qualitative Pretest Interview is a method of pretest interviewing for quality improvement of questionnaires by conceptualising the clarification of comprehension as a social process of negotiating meaning through intersubjective understanding.
- The Qualitative Pretest Interview involves interview partners as co-experts for this process in a dialogic clarification, in everyday language, of manifest and implied meanings and understanding of formulations and expressions used in draft survey questions and other standardised stimuli.

=> In QPIs we are interested in clarifying if and how the respondents understand the wording of questions, and how they want us to understand their answers and reactions to the wording of questions.

© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021

Communication strategies

- Dialogic clarification through active listening and active understanding of the interviewer
- Adopted from the Problem-centred Interview (Witzel/Reiter 2012) for the purpose of the QPI
- Problem-centred interview presented at the Research Methods Festival 2014 in the frame of another What is…? session:

  https://eprints.ncrm.ac.uk/id/eprint/3539/
- Direct negotiation of implied meaning
- Combining communication strategies of general and specific exploration

© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021

General exploration

- Collection of contextualised expressions – mostly inductive
- Applied to each survey question, item etc.
- Dynamics – mostly monologic
- Strategy:
  - Respondent is invited to read out the item/question
  - Respondent is invited to express thoughts regarding the item by thinking aloud
  - Active listening – interviewer follows the account, takes notes, prepares follow-up

© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021

Specific exploration

- Development of first interpretations
- Clarification of possible misunderstandings – mostly deductive
- Dynamics – mostly dialogic
- Active understanding – interviewer is engaged in the clarification of meaning
- Strategies:
  - **Comprehension questions**: interviewer clarifies evasive, incomplete answers
  - **Mirroring**: interviewer summarises and rephrases expressions
  - **Confrontations**: interviewer explores contradictions
- Back and forth between reference systems of interviewer resp. respondent
- Dialogue and active negotiation encourages involvement

=> Briefing!

© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021

Briefing

1. **Goal of the QPI** – interest in if/how of understanding & why of answering
2. **Establishing the interview partner as co-expert** – critical reviewer of questionnaire

   Interviewer: "...and I depend on your support, that means, first I would like you to say everything that you notice, *[IP: Uhm.]* to talk about everything that comes to your mind when you read each of the questions, when you look at the individual pages. And I depend on that, that's why I say support, uhm, that you are welcome to put your finger on it and say: 'The term is not clear to me now.' *[IP: Ok.]* ..."
3. **General exploration and thinking aloud** – flow of thoughts

   Interviewer: "What makes this situation so special is the fact that I am actually encouraging you to express everything that comes to your mind."
4. **Anticipating unusual interventions** – spontaneous interruptions, struggle

© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021

Thinking aloud & active listening

- Example of a questionnaire addressing the issue of sensitive information like income
- Respondent is asked to read the item out loud
- Interviewer (I) assumes the role of active listener

  Item: *"How concerned are your relatives, friends or your partner that you provide too much personal information to people you don't know very well?"*

  Answer categories: 1 – 2 – 3 – 4 – 5
- Interview partner (IP) reads and thinks aloud:

  "How concerned are your relatives, friends or your partner that you provide too much personal information (.) to people you don't know very well? (.) So, now I don't know what it is that relatives, friends or partners should be worried about. (.) Is it simply about my, are they worried that I make my own information available to others that I use smartphones. That's how I understand that. *[I: Yes.]* Or, uh, is it about (.) that they (.) are concerned that the information I have about the relatives. (.) So, *[I: Ah.]* yes."

© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021

Active understanding & negotiating indexicality

– Identifying ambiguous items and starting a process of dialogic clarification

1. IP: Yes, and then it's just that, it's such a mishmash, then I would just say “rather not like that”, four. [*i.e. the answer category 4*]
2. I: Mishmash, because?
3. IP: Yes, maybe my mother is totally worried and, uh, all my friends are just not worried, that’s just how it was now.
4. I: Ok, so because now we simply packed all [*I: Yes.*] contacts [*I: Yes, all.*] into this question [*I: Uhm.*], so that it is difficult to name exactly [*I: Exactly.*] who is worried. [*I: Yes.*] That means, if we wanted to, so if we were interested in what your partner or friends were saying and if we wanted to separate that, we would have to list them separately. [*I: Uhm.*] Do I understand that correctly?
5. IP: Totally. Exactly like that.

© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021

Debriefing

- Final appreciation of the interview partner’s participation and contribution
- Opportunity to address open issues
- Highlighting take-away conclusions
- Information about next steps

© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021

A note on analysis

- Transcription for textual analysis or for protocol of key aspects
- Coding, paraphrasing, content analysis, research team analysis workshops
- Optional sequential analysis
- Best practice:
  - Analysis workshops based on protocols and original recordings
  - Interview partners are represented with their original comments
  - Iterative process of listening to recording <=> discussionImmediate adjustment of items possible => time efficient
  - Documentation of process and findings

© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021

Limitations & reflection

- Variable length depending on purpose, detail and complexity
- QPIs cannot be standardised – it is a qualitative method
- QP-interviewing requires training and experience!
- Ideally, interviewers have background in qualitative-interpretive method(ology)
- Sudman and Bradburn (1982):

  "It is even more important for researchers with limited resources to pilot-test their questionnaires before spending all their money. If you do not have the resources to pilot-test your questionnaire, don't do the study."

© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021

Thank you for your interest and attention!

Questions and comments are welcome

Please use the WHOVA Q&A section

Additional comments & questions by e-mail: reiter@dji.de

© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021

References

- Bethmann, Arne/Buschle, Chrinstina/Reiter, Herwig (2019) Kognitiv oder qualitativ? Pretest-Interviews in der Fragebogenentwicklung. In: Menold, Natalja/Wolbring, Tobias (eds.) Qualitätssicherung sozialwissenschaftlicher Erhebungsinstrumente. Wiesbaden: Springer VS, pp. 159–193.
- Buschle, Christina/Reiter, Herwig/Bethmann, Arne (2021): The qualitative pretest interview for questionnaire development: outline of programme and practice (online first). In: Quality and Quantity. https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s11135-021-01156-0
- Garfinkel, Harold (1984/1967) Studies in Ethnomethodology. Cambridge: Polity Press.
- Groves, Robert M./ Lyberg, Lars (2010) Total survey error. Past, present, and future. Public Opinion Quarterly, Vol. 74, No. 5, pp. 849–879.
- Tourangeau, Roger/Rips, Lance J./Rasinski, Kenneth (2000) The Psychology of Survey Response. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Willis, Gordon B. (2005) Cognitive Interviewing. A Tool for Improving Questionnaire Design. Thousand Oaks: Sage.
- Willis, Gordon B (2015) Analysis of the Cognitive Interview in Questionnaire Design. Oxford University Press, Oxford.
- Witzel, Andreas/Reiter, Herwig (2012) The problem-centred interview. Principles and practice. Sage, London.

© Reiter/Bethmann/Buschle 2021